Even Tamil Nadu politician T.T.V. Dhinakaran was allegedly caught in Sukash's fraud net in 2017. Having read about Sasikala's nephew's desperation to appropriate Jayalalithaa's legacy and retain the "two leaves" election symbol of her party, the All India Anna DMK, Sukash approached Dhinakaran and told him that he knew officials in the Election Commission of India and could persuade them to rule in his favour for a consideration of Rs 50 crore. Later, while trying to bribe some ECI officials at a Delhi hotel, Sukash was arrested by the Delhi Police. Dhinakaran, on his part, denied the allegations.

THE FINAL HEIST

It was for this misdemeanour that Sukash was serving time as an undertrial in Tihar Jail when he discovered industrialist Shivinder Mohan Singh was a fellow inmate. Shivinder and his brother Malvinder—the former promoters of Religare Enterprises—were first arrested by the Delhi Police's Economic Offences Wing in October 2019 for misappropriation of funds, cheating, criminal conspiracy and criminal breach of trust. Based on this, the ED began probing the money-laundering aspect and in December arrested the brothers under PMLA. In Tihar since, the two may have to spend 3-7 years in jail should they be convicted.

Sukash, meanwhile, researched Shivinder extensively, allegedly with explicit help from the jail officials. In the first half of 2020, he was transferred to Rohini jail where he hatched an elaborate plan to con Shivinder's wife Aditi Singh. He allegedly bribed jail officials to get access to a cellphone and internet, while his associates kept supplying him with information on the movements of Aditi and other family members, inputs that he later used to intimidate her.

Sukash first called Aditi's cellphone on June 15, 2020. Though his smartphone had an Israeli SIM card, Sukash used a spoofing app, so that the number that flashed on Aditi's phone was from the Union home ministry. Introducing himself as Union law secretary Anoop Kumar, Sukash told Aditi that he was calling on the instruction of the Prime Minister's Office. Given Shivinder's expertise in healthcare, Sukash/Kumar told Aditi, the government wanted to include him in a top committee on Covid and therefore wanted to help the jailed businessman get bail soon.

Sukash called Aditi again later in the day, this time posing as Abhinav, undersecretary to Kumar, and reiterated the government's intention to help her family. It was after three calls that 'Abhinav' asked Aditi to contribute Rs 20 crore to the party fund. The payment was made in two instalments—Rs 1 crore routed to Hong Kong and Rs 19 crore delivered in cash in Delhi. Demands for more money followed. Simultaneously, Sukash recounted a lot of accurate personal details about the Singhs and their children, instilling in her the fear that he would actually harm them. So much so that Aditi could not bring herself to discuss the matter even with her husband or anyone else.

All the unusual activity in Aditi's accounts alerted ED officials, who confronted her. Breaking down, she revealed how she was being conned

Aditi sold jewellery, borrowed money from friends and family and liquidated all her assets, including investments made for their children's future, to arrange for the funds. Her wealth manager Shikha Singh introduced her to two individuals—Manoj Mangla and Manoj Godha—who helped her convert her assets into cash as well as transfers abroad in lieu of high commissions. Komal Poddar, bank manager at RBL Bank, and two other acquaintances, Navneet Jain and Rahul Wadhwa too helped with some transactions.

Between June 2020 and May 2021, Aditi paid Sukash Rs 200 crore in 40 transactions. All the cash pickups in Delhi were done by Sukash's aides Deepak Ramnani and Pradeep Ramdanee. The flurry of unusual activity aroused the suspicions of the ED, which was already monitoring Aditi's transactions, in connection with the money-laundering case, that her husband was in jail for. When the agency confronted her, Aditi apparently broke down and told them what she was going through. It was at the ED's instance that she filed a complaint with the Delhi Police. The latter, in turn, arrested Sukash on August 8, 2021, while the ED registered a money-laundering case against him based on the police FIR.

But if you thought the story ends here, think again. While tracking his money trail, the Delhi Police and the ED stumbled upon another of Sukash's well-kept secrets.

THE LOVE OF HIS LIFE

Enter Bollywood actress Jacqueline Fernandez, who has now been named co-accused under PMLA for knowingly enjoying the "proceeds of the crime"—in this case the Rs 200 crore loot from Aditi Singh. The ED chargesheet details gifts worth around Rs 7 crore that Sukash apparently bestowed on Jacqueline and her family, though she has not admitted to accepting all the gifts mentioned in the list. The actress also claims she was not aware of Sukash's real identity, but the ED chargesheet says that within a month of her conversations with Sukash, she had come across news articles detailing who he was, yet chose to continue accepting gifts from him.

Jacqueline's father Elroy Fernandez